

CORRESPONDING WITH MY CHILDHOOD SELF

GOALS OF THE EXERCISE

1. Learn how childhood trauma resulted in interpersonal problems and addiction.
2. Resolve past childhood/family issues, leading to less fear, anger, and depression, and to greater self-esteem and confidence.
3. Overcome denial, minimization, and intellectualization of the effects of childhood trauma.
4. Reframe childhood perceptions of childhood situations using adult insights.
5. Overcome a pattern of feeling emotionally isolated and unsupported by providing a corrective experience of having childhood feelings heard and accepted.

ADDITIONAL HOMEWORK THAT CAN BE APPLICABLE TO CLIENTS WHO HAVE EXPERIENCED CHILDHOOD TRAUMA

- Am I Having Difficulty Letting Go?
- Am I Teaching My Children Addictive Patterns?
- Coping with Addiction and PTSD or Other Anxiety Disorders
- Moving On with My Life
- Safe and Peaceful Place Meditation
- Setting and Maintaining Boundaries
- Understanding Family History
- Using Books and Other Media Resources
- What Do I Want for My Children?
- Working through Shame

ADDITIONAL PROBLEMS FOR WHICH THIS EXERCISE MAY BE USEFUL

- Adult-Child-of-an-Alcoholic (ACOA) Traits
- Parent-Child Relational Problems
- Posttraumatic Stress Disorder (PTSD)

SUGGESTIONS FOR PROCESSING THIS EXERCISE WITH THE CLIENT

The “Corresponding with My Childhood Self” activity is suited for clients who are stuck in modes of reaction formed in response to childhood trauma, and who use denial, minimization, or intellectualization to block painful feelings related to that trauma. It may be most useful after incidents in which

clients respond inappropriately to adult situations in ways that appear to be related to unresolved childhood trauma. This may be used in conjunction with videotherapy (see the book *Rent Two Films And Let's Talk in the Morning* by John W. Hesley and Jan G. Hesley, also published by John Wiley & Sons). Follow-up may include other therapeutic techniques for addressing unresolved trauma and/or teaching and enhancing healthy coping mechanisms.

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When you hear the phrase “inner child,” what do you think about?

Do you ever feel like a child pretending to be an adult, with a grown-up body but a child’s feelings and reactions? That’s a normal feeling—most people feel this way at times.

Do memories of things that happened in your childhood sometimes feel as fresh and painful as if they had just happened? For people who were traumatized as children, that’s a common experience, too. It often feels as if we’re stuck, unable to get over long-ago events.

The purpose of this exercise is to help you get unstuck, by understanding and resolving the impacts of painful childhood experiences that may still haunt you in your adult life, and to help you use your adult strengths and understanding to heal the pain and fear of the child within you.

1. To prepare for this exercise, think about a childhood experience that still bothers you and that you would like to put to rest. If no specific event stands out in your memory, you can work on your feelings and thoughts about a certain period of time, perhaps a difficult year.
2. If you can, find a photograph of yourself as a child at the time of the event or period of which you’re thinking. If you don’t have a photo from the exact time you have in mind, one taken within a couple of years before or after will serve the purpose. If you don’t have any childhood pictures, you can still do the exercise, but a picture will help you focus.
3. Set aside at least an hour to work on this exercise without interruptions or distractions, in a place where you have privacy and feel safe. You will need a notebook or some lined paper, a pen or pencil, and the picture you chose.
4. Draw a vertical line down the center of a sheet of paper, so as to create two columns. Over the left-hand column, write the name or nickname your friends call you today. Over the right-hand column, write the name you went by at that time in your childhood. If it’s the same name, add your age at the time of the event or period on which you’re working to the column on the right.
5. Look at the photograph and think about the child you see. What is going on in this child’s world? What does he or she think and feel? If you could jump into a time machine and go talk with this child, what would you want to say to him or her?

6. In the left-hand column, write a little bit of what you would first say to this child if you had that time machine and had the chance to talk with him or her. Stop after a sentence or two.
7. Switch to the right-hand column, and switch your pen or pencil to your opposite or weak hand—your left hand if you're right-handed, or vice versa. Look at the photo again, and remember what it felt like to be that child. Imagine having this adult in front of you, saying the things that you just wrote in the first column. As that child, what would your answers be? Using your weak hand, write a brief reply in the right column.
8. Switch back to the left-hand column and your strong hand and write your adult's answers to whatever your child just said. Continue writing back and forth, having a conversation on paper, using your strong hand to write your adult self's words and your weak hand for your child self's words. Don't worry about what words or feelings come out—just keep going, writing whatever comes to mind. This may feel awkward, both physically and emotionally. That's okay. Being a child often felt awkward, and using your opposite hand helps in getting in closer touch with how it felt—may still feel at times.
9. Stop after no more than half an hour. If you feel like it, your adult self may want to make an appointment with your child self to meet again another time and continue the conversation. Then take some time to read back through both columns and think about what you wrote.
10. Did you find any surprises, either in what you as an adult said to your childhood self, or in what your inner child had to say? If so, what were the surprises, and what might you do differently as a result of what you've learned? Write a few lines about this.

11. What would it have been like as a child to have an adult in your life with whom you could have talked about what was then going on? When you were writing for your inner child, how did it feel to have someone paying attention?

Be sure to bring this handout back to your next session with your therapist, and be prepared to talk about your thoughts and feelings about the exercise.